27 February, 2026

Invitation to a Global Freshwater Fish Ex-situ Conservation Assessment (ECA) Workshop, Albuquerque, New Mexico, US

Dear participant,

You are kindly invited to participate in a workshop to assess, prioritize and develop recommendations for ex-situ conservation of freshwater fish globally. This workshop is part of a collaborative project jointly coordinated, led, and funded by the New Mexico BioPark Society, SHOAL, Re:wild, the IUCN SSC Conservation Planning Specialist Group (CPSG), and the IUCN SSC Freshwater Fish Specialist Group, with additional funding made possible by the Seaworld Conservation Fund, whose commitment will help make this initiative and its subsequent impact possible.

The ABQ BioPark (Albuquerque, New Mexico) will host the workshop from June 1-5, 2026 (inclusive), with organizational support from the New Mexico BioPark Society. **Please confirm your participation with Michael Chase (conservationcoordinator@bioparksociety.org) by March 13, 2026,** to allow for timely progression of workshop logistics.

The primary objective of this workshop is to assess and decide whether and which ex-situ management activities should be recommended for a selection of ~360 of the world's most imperiled freshwater fishes. This assessment will apply standard CPSG conservation planning principles and methods and follow the IUCN SSC Guidelines on the Use of Ex Situ Management for Species Conservation, considering the benefit, feasibility and risk of potential ex-situ management options under consideration. Once reviewed, species profiles and recommendations will be published in a comprehensive post-workshop report and will be used to support ongoing activities identified in Resolution 111 of the recent IUCN World Conservation Congress. The outcome of this workshop will significantly progress efforts toward a fully comprehensive list of freshwater fishes in need of ex-situ conservation action, providing a critical first step and a foundational base of knowledge that can be expanded over time.

Recommendations collated through the ECA process will serve as an initial prioritization for imperiled freshwater fishes globally and can be modified or expanded as new information becomes available. Your expertise and relevant insights will be valuable to this effort, and we encourage you to have your contributions and relevant information available for reference during the workshop.

We recognize that current geopolitical tensions may influence and/or impact abilities to travel to the United States. If this is the case, please let us know at the email address stated above, so we can assess the scale of the issue among the participants and consider appropriate solutions.

An agenda, species list and logistics packet will be sent out in the coming months, with participants being responsible for the cost of their travel and accommodation.

Your expertise and insights will be valuable to this effort, and we very much hope that you will be able to participate in this important, collaborative conservation planning event for freshwater fish. Don't hesitate to get in touch if you have further questions.

Yours sincerely,

Julie Miller Rugg

NMBPS Executive Director

Tim Lyons

NMBPS Conservation Director